CONNECT DAILY

Wednesday 14 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- ASCL (school/college leaders' union) has passed a motion of no confidence in Ofsted's leadership this week, citing unaddressed wellbeing harm from the report-card framework and threatening an industrial-action ballot.
- NEU is pushing back on a ~£3.3bn teacher-pension contribution saving that DfE plans to claw back from school budgets from April 2027, rather than letting schools keep it.
- 2026 phonics check results are the first since the pandemic to match 2019 national levels (82% of Year 1) - but the disadvantage gap looks unmoved, flagged below as an uncertain figure.
- Locally: South Yorkshire's Mayor has launched a Youth Impact Fund for 11-19 year-olds, and Sheffield councillors meet Monday to fund two secondary school expansions.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry (national deadline 31 Oct).

19 Oct 2026 — Sheffield Finance & Performance Committee votes on £602k funding for the Firth Park Academy expansion.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

2 Nov 2026 — Extended deadline for schools to complete autumn census free school meals eligibility rechecks.

ACCOUNTABILITY & OFSTED

- **ASCL declares no confidence in Ofsted leadership** The union's ruling council says it has seen no meaningful progress addressing wellbeing harm from the renewed report-card inspection framework, and wants inspections paused for an urgent review. Members will now be surveyed on a possible industrial-action ballot. (Schools Week)

FUNDING

- **NEU pushes back on £3.3bn pensions clawback** Employer pension contributions fall from 28.6% to 17.6% from April 2027, but DfE has confirmed school funding will be reduced to reflect the saving rather than schools keeping it, unlike a similar local-government pensions saving. NEU general secretary Daniel Kebede argues the money is urgently needed by schools. (Schools Week / Tes)

INCLUSION & ATTAINMENT

- **Phonics results back to pre-pandemic levels - gap claims conflict** DfE's 2026 phonics screening check shows 82% of Year 1 pupils met the expected standard, matching 2019 for the first time since the pandemic, with SEN attainment also at its highest since the check began. Commentators flag that more pupils not sitting the check flatters the headline, and reports disagree on whether the disadvantaged-pupil gap (cited variously at 4 or 17 percentage points) has actually narrowed - worth checking DfE's full release before quoting a figure. (Explore Education Statistics (DfE))

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Mayor launches Youth Impact Fund for South Yorkshire's 11-19s** Oliver Coppard has launched grants of £2,000-£10,000 for talented young people aged 11-19 across South Yorkshire, covering coaching, equipment, course fees and travel - run with The King's Trust and South Yorkshire's Community Foundation, seeded with £25,000 from the combined authority. Teachers and community leaders can nominate pupils now. (Public Sector Executive)

  → **For your school:** *Consider nominating MAPs pupils who'd benefit.*

- **Sheffield set to expand two secondaries for 2027-29 demand** The council's finance and performance committee meets Monday 19 October to approve passing £602,000 of government funding to Firth Park Academy (admission number rising 240 to 270) and a temporary 30-place expansion at Parkwood Academy, ahead of a projected secondary places deficit in 2027/28 and 2028/29. (The Star)

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

82%

of Year 1 pupils met the expected phonics standard in 2026 - the first time national attainment has returned to pre-pandemic (2019) levels, though analysts flag the disadvantaged-pupil gap may not have narrowed.

DfE phonics screening check, 2026

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment

Source	Type	What we track
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.